

DECISION, DECISION, DECISION

WHAT IF YOU NEVER HAVE TO TAKE ANOTHER LEAP OF FAITH? DATA ABOUT ANYTHING AND EVERYTHING IS AT YOUR DISPOSAL AND HERE'S HOW YOU CAN USE IT!

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Even if you don't suffer from Decidophobia – the fear of making decisions (yeah, that's a thing) – making decisions isn't always easy. Especially if the circumstances are quite new and you have absolutely no experience to fall back on. Worry not, you have Big Data to your rescue which is being seen as a panacea for even something as tough as a catch-22.

Ever since we were cavemen, we rely on the most experienced amongst us to make the toughest decisions. And sometimes, it isn't up to just one person which then requires a group of experienced managers to be consulted. It takes the cumulative experience and intuition of multiple individuals to take a high-stakes decision. The more individuals you have, the better the decision. Except such individuals don't come cheap, but data does. And evidence supporting the increased use of data in decision making is growing by the day. Since the human element is largely removed from such decisions, the business implications from a decision based on data also ends up being more profitable.

The problem with this approach is that the amount of data generated is too voluminous and unstructured. And creating data models by training a Machine Learning algorithm takes too much time for such decision making processes to be used in untested waters. But the mere fact that companies such as IBM are investing billions of dollars into their systems should tell you a thing or two about how important a role Big Data is going to play. And close on the heels of these big organisations, even the little guys are lining up to harness the power of Big Data.

HOW THE BIG GUYS DO IT

Building consumer intelligence

Businesses thrive on customers and customers like to be pampered. While you local 'mom and pop' stores can easily remember the names of their customers along with what's been happening in their lives, the big corporations don't have it that easy. Given the sheer number of customers, it's next to impossible to remember a hundred thousand names and cater to them accordingly. So what do these big firms do? They implement CRM systems that mine customer data to generate profiles for individual customers

which is then passed onto the assigned "representative". This data allows the representative to develop a rapport akin to something that's formed over years of conversation in just a matter of minutes.

And it's not just about developing familiarity but this profile also allows your the representative to devise the right strategy to sell you the right product and maximise profit. This also ensures that the smaller customers aren't alienated and consecutively don't move to another service provider. And by sifting through tonnes of metadata generated from social media, companies can figure out what members of a particular community are fond of. This allows the hospitality industry to cater their services to a particular demographic better than they would have otherwise done.

Improving efficiency

Another aspect of businesses is operational efficiency. As companies grow, so does the complexity of its operations and operational processes need to evolve to handle this increasing complexity. And while traditional methods of improving efficiency might go a long way, changing